COMPONENTS · SWEET

Dark Chocolate Crémeux

Vanilla custard poured over dark chocolate, blended smooth and chilled until set.

MAKES **ABOUT 900 TO 950 G (3 1/2 TO 3 3/4 CUPS)**
ACTIVE **1 HR** · TOTAL **5 HR, IDEALLY OVERNIGHT**
PAN **MEDIUM SAUCEPAN** · HEAT **LOW, STOVETOP**

BEFORE YOU START

- Chop the chocolate and put it in a large, deep bowl with room for a stick blender. Set a fine sieve over it. The custard has to hit the chocolate hot, so this is ready first.
- Butter at room temperature, if using.
- Have an instant-read thermometer, a rubber spatula and a stick blender to hand.
- Set the yolk bowl on a damp towel so it stays put while you whisk and pour at the same time.
- Use real chocolate whose only fat is cocoa butter. Compound or melting chocolate made with palm or vegetable oil will not set.

INGREDIENTS

Custard (crème anglaise)

	1 cup	Whole or 2% milk 240 ml
	1 cup	Heavy cream, 35% fat 240 ml
	4	Large egg yolks
100 g	1/2 cup	Sugar
	1/4 tsp	Sea salt
	1 tbsp	Vanilla extract

Crémeux

340 g	Dark chocolate chopped, at least 55% cacao
50 g	Unsalted butter optional, softened

METHOD

Custard (crème anglaise)

1. Heat the milk and cream over medium, stirring now and then so the bottom doesn't scorch. Take it off the heat once it steams. Don't let it boil.

2. Meanwhile, whisk the yolks, sugar, salt and vanilla until smooth and pale. Dissolving the sugar into the yolks first cushions them against the heat.

3. Pour about half the hot dairy into the yolks in a thin stream, whisking the whole time. Warming the yolks gradually is what keeps them from scrambling. Scrape the bowl and whisk once more.

4. Pour it all back into the saucepan, whisk, and set over low heat. Stir constantly with a spatula, scraping the bottom, sides and corners. If it thickens too fast, lift the pan off the heat and keep stirring to spread the heat out, then return it.
   WAIT **4 TO 10 MIN**
   ✓ *Coats the back of a spoon,* **180F to 185F (82C to 85C).** *Never let it boil.*

Crémeux

5. Pour the hot custard through the sieve onto the chocolate. The sieve catches any bits of cooked egg. Cover the bowl with a plate.
   WAIT **1 MIN**

6. Stir until the chocolate is fully melted. Add the butter now, while it's warm, and stir it in.

7. Blend with a stick blender, keeping the blade fully submerged so you don't whip in air. This emulsifies the cocoa butter into the custard, which is where the silky texture comes from.
   ✓ *Smooth, thick and glossy*

8. Press plastic wrap directly onto the whole surface to stop a skin forming. Chill until set. For tarts or cups, pour into them first and chill there.
   WAIT **4 HR, IDEALLY OVERNIGHT**
   ✓ *Firm and scoopable, like soft ganache*

9. To spread or pipe, let the chilled crémeux sit at room temperature until it softens. It also tastes silkier served at room temperature than cold.
   ✓ *Spreads easily without tearing*

NOTES

Make ahead & storage

- Airtight in the fridge for **4 to 5 days**. It picks up fridge smells, so seal it well.
- Freezes for **2 months**, airtight. Thaw in the fridge or at room temperature; the texture may shift a little.

Substitutions

- Milk chocolate: cut the sugar to **50 g (1/4 cup)**.
- White chocolate: cut the sugar to **50 g (1/4 cup)**. It sets much softer; use one made with cocoa butter and consider gelatin.
- Butter is for mouthfeel only. Leave it out with no loss of structure.
- Mocha: dissolve 3 to 4 tsp instant coffee granules in the hot custard before straining.
- Extra hold (warm room, heavy layers on top): bloom 1 1/2 tsp powdered gelatin in 2 tbsp water and stir into the warm custard. Up to 2 1/2 tsp in 3 tbsp water if it's hot out.
- Dairy-free: plant milk plus unsweetened coconut cream, a vegan dark chocolate, and vegan butter or none.
- Nutella or fruit purée can't replace the chocolate. The chocolate is what sets it; without it you need gelatin.

Pairs with

- Chocolate Pavlova: the meringue uses the whites, this uses the 4 yolks. Spread it on the cooled shell just before serving, under the whipped cream, so it doesn't soften the meringue.
- Something sharp to cut the richness: raspberries, cherries or passion fruit.
- Toasted chopped hazelnuts, folded in after blending. They stay crunchy, but go stale after a few days.

COMPONENTS
SWEET
CHOCOLATE · MAKE-AHEAD · FREEZER-FRIENDLY
USES EGG YOLKS

Adapted from Dini Kodippili, The Flavor Bender, theflavorbender.com/creamy-chocolate-cremeux-recipe. Method rewritten and condensed for personal kitchen use.